2.1 Seeking Help from Europe

It's hard to face a tough challenge alone. This is especially true in times of war. During the Revolution, America looked for help from other countries.

MAIN IDEA Assistance from European powers and from heroes of various backgrounds helped Americans overcome some of their disadvantages in the American Revolution.

POWERFUL FRIENDS

The alliance between France and the United States did not happen immediately. Taking advantage of the Continental Army's momentum, the Continental Congress sent Benjamin Franklin and John Adams to Europe. Congress hoped to persuade France to become an official ally of the United States. The French considered Britain to be their main enemy and wanted to avenge their loss in the French and Indian War. These considerations helped Franklin and Adams convince France to sign the Treaty of Alliance in February 1778 and provide the United States with financial assistance.

France and Spain were allies, and they both had lost significant lands in North America at the end of the French and Indian War. In addition to money and supplies, France provided the Americans with troops. Both nations helped the Americans by drawing Britain's military and naval attention in different directions. The French navy engaged the British in the West Indies, pulling resources away from the North American mainland. Spanish military leader Bernardo de Gálvez forced the British to send troops to the Mississippi Valley to defend forts formerly held by the Spanish. Then Gálvez helped defeat the British in Florida and claimed that territory for Spain.

HEROES FROM HOME AND ABROAD

France and Spain also played pivotal roles in affecting the course of the war. You've learned that Tadeusz Kościuszko from Poland helped win the Battles of Saratoga. You've also read about the contributions of Prussia's **Baron Friedrich von Steuben** at Valley Forge. From von Steuben, the inexperienced American soldiers rapidly learned skills such as marching, making quick decisions in combat, and using weapons, including the **bayonet** (BAY-uh-net), a sharp blade attached to a musket.

The **Marquis de Lafayette** (mar-KEE duh lah-fy-EHT), a French nobleman, had already offered his assistance to the American war effort and had become a general in the Continental Army. He took a break from the fighting and returned to France to help Franklin and Adams get funding and support from the king. With that goal accomplished, Lafayette came back to America and took part in many battles, including the one that would end the war.

Although the Continental Army did not actively welcome African Americans, those who sympathized with the Patriot cause found ways to help. An enslaved man named **James Armistead** was allowed by his owner to spy for Lafayette. Gaining the trust of British officers, Armistead gathered information that helped the Americans win key battles.

Even with France and Spain helping to pay for some of the costs of the war, the United States faced major economic challenges during the conflict. Before the war, Britain and the West Indies had been markets for American goods and sources of goods for the American markets. Now British ships **blockaded** American ports by refusing to let vessels enter or leave these harbors. Towns and farms were destroyed as battles raged near or around them. And war is expensive. American troops had to be fed, and they needed uniforms, dependable weapons, and a steady supply of ammunition. Battle wounds and

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Boston Athenaeum, Boston

In this 1853 painting by Andre Jolly, Benjamin Franklin is shown as the center of attention among French royalty at the home of Princess Elizabeth. Diane de Polignac, placing a laurel wreath on Franklin's head, ran the household. Elizabeth stands behind her brother, King Louis XVI, who is seated at the right. To his right is his wife, Marie-Antoinette, the queen.

outbreaks of disease led to an increasing need for medical supplies. And, of course, the soldiers expected to be paid.

Unfortunately, Congress did not have the power to collect taxes to help fund the war. Instead, Congress decided to make up for the shortfall by printing more money, even though it had no real wealth to back it up. In 1782, John Adams obtained a loan from Dutch bankers but also looked to American citizens for additional help.

Many Americans contributed what they could to the cause. For example, American Jewish **financier** Haym Salomon lent funds to help pay the costs of the revolution. A financier raises and provides funds for a business or undertaking. Salomon's generous gesture was never repaid, however, and he died in 1785 without a penny to his name. Financial problems were not the only challenges Americans faced, however. The war was still far from over.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did France and Spain help the Americans?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why did other nations offer to help the Americans?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** How did Britain wage war against the Americans off the battlefield?

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